

Understanding the virus

Doctors already knew that the HIV virus is passed from person to person in certain body fluids, such as blood. However, some groups of people were more likely to become infected by it than others.

In the early 1990s, Quarraisha discovered that in South Africa, young people—and especially teenage girls—were most at risk. She decided to devote her career to understanding why, and to using her discoveries to find new ways to prevent the virus from spreading.

Worldwide support

A red ribbon is a symbol of awareness (knowledge of) and support for people living with HIV around the world. Quarraisha leads a large team of researchers that tries to find vaccines, treatments, and cures for HIV and AIDS.



By working closely with communities in South Africa, Quarraisha discovered that young women couldn't easily find information about health. They didn't like asking adults for advice and preferred to talk about health issues with friends. She learned that without expert knowledge, false information could spread quickly.

Quarraisha suggested that girls and young women should be taught how to avoid catching the virus. She also developed a medicine that stops the virus from spreading, especially among women. Nearly 8 million South Africans live with HIV, but Quarraisha's work has already provided treatment to many of them.

